



Discussion Guide: Amy-Jill Levine

Jesus, Judaism, and Justice

Reflect

- Amy-Jill opens her talk by noting that she has been consigned to hell a lot. Has something similar ever happened to you? Have you ever felt judged for what you believe? What were the circumstances and how did you respond?
- In Christian circles, faith is often understood primarily in terms of believing the right things about God (orthodoxy). But in Judaism, doing the right things (orthopraxy) is typically more essential. What are the disadvantages of over-emphasizing belief over right practice? What about vice versa?
- Amy-Jill describes her last conversation with her mom before she died. In that conversation, she assured her mom that she would experience a wonderful afterlife – even though Amy-Jill usually doesn't believe in such things. But she says, "In that moment, I believed every word I said." Have you ever experienced a moment of unusually strong belief about mysterious things? How do you interpret those experiences, or Amy-Jill's? Where do you think that confidence comes from?

Respond

- Amy-Jill proposes that faith is a matter of "love," not "logic." Belief is something we only receive as a gift. To what extent do you agree? Would you state it differently? How would these various perspectives on "belief" impact your attitude and behavior toward those who do not believe in Jesus, or in God, the same way you do?
- There is some back-and-forth in Amy-Jill's talk between John 14:1–6 ("I am the way... no one comes to the father except through me.") and Matthew 25:31–46 (the parable of the sheep and the goats). What does each text suggest is truly required of people of faith? Does one trump the other? How do you hold these views in conversation in your own life?